



Before Buying an MFD

- ❑ Consider your Usage Pattern: If you print and copy more, choose a copier engine-based MFD. If you print more and copy less, opt for a printer engine-based MFD. If fax is your main concern, opt for a specialised Laser fax that doubles as a laser printer and scanner
- ❑ Look for handy features, such as paper capacity, buffer memory, duplex printing, toner save, etc.
- ❑ Make sure the MFD can print on the kinds of paper products you use, such as envelopes and index cards
- ❑ Pay attention to upgradeability and scalability. Upgrade options will extend the life of the device, as your needs grow
- ❑ Check the type of warranty offered. Laser MFDs are bulky and heavy—lugging them around is not feasible, so make sure your model is covered by an on-site warranty
- ❑ Try the console interface to figure out how to operate the device
- ❑ Check out the control panel. It should have a good LCD panel to display status messages and warnings

HP's LJ 3380 dominated the printing performance. Though rated to print at 20 PPM, it managed a fast 18 PPM. It was the only device to break the 10-second barrier for the first printout, taking just 9 seconds. The Samsung's 4216F came in second.

Scanning

All the MFDs have scanners with a maximum optical resolution of 600 dpi. This is enough to enlarge a 4x6 inch photograph, and print it without any visible graininess. HP and Brother MFDs support 9,600 dpi 'enhanced' resolution, whereas Samsung and Xerox top out at 4,800 dpi. All except Canon have the 'Scan to PC' feature so, you can not use it as a PC scanner.

All the devices use a flatbed scanner with 24-bit colour depth. These are better than the sheet-fed variety, since they can be used with a variety of sources, and generally produce better scans. Most of the MFDs also come with Automatic Document Feeders to facilitate scanning multiple sheets.

Nothing beats Brother in terms of scanning speed. The Brother models were nearly four times faster than their slowest competitors—Samsung and Xerox. The Brother MFDs, also yielded superb colour reproduction and saturation. The devices from Samsung and Xerox were able to match the Brother only in terms of spatial resolution.

Copying

All these MFDs permit a maximum of 99 copies of a document. Standard copying features include Reduce or Enlarge, magnification up to 400 per cent and standalone copying. Collation is another feature that is common to all of them.

The models from Samsung and Xerox have additional special features such as clone, poster,

HP's LJ3380 dominated the printing performance tests. It clocked 18 pages per minute and broke the 10-second barrier for the first printout

auto-fit, etc, which add value. Though these may not be used on a day-to-day basis, they definitely come in handy to print posters, banners, etc. As for copying speeds, HP's 3380 convincingly thrashed all the other MFDs in this category to walk away with top honours.

Faxing

Faxing was limited to Brother's MFC 8820D, Canon's IC D680, HP's LJ3030 and LJ3380, Samsung's SCX-4216F and Xerox's PE16. Brother-MFC 8820D saves up to 500 fax pages in memory for you to retrieve them later. In comparison, Samsung and Xerox both accommodate 320 pages and HP's 3380 stores up to 250 pages. All of them have fax scheduling to send pre-timed faxes automatically. Brother, Samsung and Xerox models offer 'On hook dialling' to monitor the connection, handy in the absence of a telephone handset.

Verdict for Workgroup MFDs

All said and done, Samsung's SCX-4216F scored over its competitors with its decent performance, good set of features and an acceptable price. Though HP's LJ 3380 was by far the best performer, it lost the overall crown owing to its high price tag. If performance is your concern, opt for HP.

Heavy-duty MFDs

Heavy-duty MFDs are good for high volumes of printing and copying. They have low running costs, are rugged and offer longer duty cycles.

Three models from Canon, and one each from Samsung, Sharp, Ricoh, Toshiba and Xerox fit into this category. Depending on your

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Workgroup MFDs



HP LJ 3380

The speedy printer makes it the top performer, but at a steep price

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